CONSUL GUIDE TO
PERSONAL GROWTH

Bring your most vibrant self to all that you do, find balance, and live a fulfilled life

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Personal Growth Matters to Consuls

Consuls have an amazing talent for being both the life of the party and the one who is looking after everyone else. They are one of the most outgoing personality types, able to connect with others regardless of their individual circumstances. At the same time, they are always mindful of the people around them and are likely to check on their well-being (paying close attention to perceived stragglers). Innately warm people, Consuls tend to be popular individuals, and this can be attributed to the three pillars that define their value system – cooperation, socialization, and community.

Everybody has gifts and strengths, and personal growth revolves around reinforcing the good and developing that which could be improved. Just as an athlete may grow muscles and skills, Consuls may slowly build upon traits like resilience, perseverance, and open-mindedness, to name a few.

However, just as Consuls have strengths, they also have their weaknesses. Personal development reduces the obstacles that lie on the path of fulfillment. Most of the time, finding balance can neutralize the challenges caused by weaknesses. But, sometimes, the greatest way to reduce the impact of a weakness is to accept it and, consequently, take the power from it. If people understand their weaknesses and blend them into their lives, they might discover strategies to work around them more naturally. It's as author George R.R. Martin penned in his novel *A Game of Thrones*: "Never forget what you are, for surely

the world will not. Make it your strength. Then it can never be your weakness. Armor yourself in it, and it will never be used to hurt you."

Working Smarter, Not Harder

Consuls have a tendency to take on a lot of work, much of it being the tasks of others. Their reliability and dependability are two of their defining traits, and they make sure that others know that they can be counted on. This isn't for recognition or glory but because Consuls embrace helping others as part of their contribution to the community. However, to give fully, one must also take from themselves. Consuls work until they're drained of energy and enthusiasm, and they can struggle to halt their duties, even if they're miserable. Growth for them is often a matter of learning how to balance their lives and how to restore vibrancy once they've lost it.

Most find balance and happiness in everydayness. On the other hand, Consuls do tend to overload their lives. They can become rigidly loyal and neglect getting the rest that they need. "A little hard work never hurt anyone" is true, but too much can do damage. Some may forget that they have a right to take care of themselves while they're taking care of others. Balance and self-care often hold a crucial place in Consuls' personal development.

The following chapters explore four areas of strength and related weaknesses and offer some suggestions for Consuls who want to achieve more balance.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Self-Responsibility

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Thomas Edison said, "The three great essentials to achieve anything worthwhile are, first, hard work; second, stick-to-itiveness; third, common sense." "Hard work, stick-to-itiveness, common sense" might serve as a mantra for most Consuls. While they may not always succeed in fulfilling these goals, Consuls still strive to realize these qualities.

Belief in Personal Choice

Whether at home or at work, Consuls cultivate the ability to organize and accomplish things in their life. They practice healthy habits to ensure optimal performance – training themselves to study material until they thoroughly understand it, for example. They are likely to view themselves at least partially responsible for any successes or failures throughout their lives and will work to praise or correct themselves.

Consuls have very strong loyalty to their community, and especially their family. They strive to achieve goalposts that their community has deemed as safe and successful, but even with that being said, Consuls, when balanced, understand that they have the ability to choose a different route if they'd like to. Community opinion is important, yes, but Consuls are ultimately the captain of their own ship.

Belief in Moderation

Consuls have the gift of tolerance. Of course, they will interject their opinion, if needed, but they are slow to lose faith in a system (or person) that may be temporarily failing them. They tend to push through situations even if it requires some personal sacrifice.

This high tolerance threshold also lends itself to how they work. The most mundane work is no problem for Consuls if they grasp its purpose or if it's paired with a strong sense of obligation. Consuls would rather work overtime and lose sleep than turn in shoddy or incomplete work, and if they know that the work they're doing is helping others, this sense of duty intensifies.

However, just as they know work is important, they also understand the need for relaxation and self-care. If Consuls feel their ends fraying, they will take a moment to take themselves out of a stressful situation, to meditate upon it, and then make a decision that is in their best interest.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Personal and professional growth occurs when Consuls use their sense of responsibility and dedication to move forward in life. However, as with all good things, diligence can shift from a powerful tool to a demanding tyrant if not properly balanced against other considerations.

Too Much Responsibility, Too Little Self-Care

Consuls' self-esteem and confidence are built upon their successful execution of responsibilities. When they are not feeling great about themselves or their lives, their sense of responsibility may "overheat" in search of a positive sense of themselves. Instead of integrating self-care and rest into their lives, they may push relentlessly to feel that sense of responsible accomplishment.

Without taking time for themselves and finding some way to relax, Consuls are likely to experience burnout. When someone is burned out, they become exhausted and lose their zeal for things that may have once excited them. It makes them lose motivation. The exhausted Consul might find it hard to get out of bed in the morning or to carry out even the most routine activities.

When Burnout Burns Others

When Consuls aren't feeling well, they tend to be vocal about it. It's bad enough to consider how burnout may affect Consuls, but one should also consider how it will spill over to their relationships. While they think they are pleasing the boss, the boss may see a worn-out employee who may not be working as efficiently as they should, despite their over-the-top efforts.

One should also consider how people who become burned out typically have short fuses. Excessive stress has damaged many a home, and Consuls, when stressed, will take their aggressions out on those around them without realizing their own faults. In the end, Consuls may harm the very people they intend to look after by not dealing with stress.

The health implications of stress are well-known and can easily be researched on the Internet. There are long-term consequences when stress is not managed. Consuls who don't deal with stress may find that their capacity to take care of others becomes limited in the future.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Assessment: Is the Stress Worth It?

Consuls who find themselves suffering from responsibility overload may need to take some strong measures to remedy any related problems. First, they should assess whether their relentless efforts are paying off or not. Working exceedingly hard may indeed be the appropriate thing to do at times. But it can also exact a toll on an individual. Matching the cost to the benefit is essential. It can be counterproductive for Consuls to assume that strenuous work is the solution to all concerns.

Consuls will typically choose action over ruminating over things. The action doesn't necessarily have to be bold. It could be as simple as tying up a loose end or attending to minute details that need completing. This can be a wonderful asset for the productive person. However, learning to prioritize that which has proven to be important and balancing it with self-care can make vigorously exerting oneself a more reasonable approach. Asking "why?" a bit more can help set a clearer path – especially when Consuls' need to feel responsible begins to overheat.

Stress Management for Those Who Roll Their Eyes at the Idea

When stressed, Consuls will do well to remember the following – spend more time with the people who bring out their best, rather than their stress. For Consuls, the best form of stress management is to be with those who have the talent to calm them down. Social engagement plays a huge role in destressing Consuls, and they can find a soothing presence in a friend, parent, or even counselor.

When Consuls do feel overwhelmed, having a space to drop emotional baggage can be most helpful. Spending some time writing out their concerns and their reactions to life can be like talking to a friend. A useful alternative might be actually talking to a supportive friend or spouse. For some Consuls, it may take thinking about venting as something that is useful and not just a self-indulgence – although there is nothing wrong with indulging oneself.

To gain credibility with Consuls, it may be important to note that stress management is not called "stress elimination." Stress, when balanced, has its place, and Consuls uniquely know where reasonable tension

fits in their lives. Stress keeps Consuls alert and motivated. It is only problematic when stressors are the only game pieces on the board and no other choice is available. It is something to be managed but not necessarily sidestepped.

Often, hardworking people like Consuls roll their eyes at the concept of stress-management courses, but stress-management is about becoming more productive in one's own life. It should streamline actions and use of energy. Stress management involves finding some pie to balance diligence with some relaxation and even some pleasure. A thorough stress-management course not only teaches how to deal with stress in the moment. It can also help Consuls plan their days, weeks, months, even their entire lives, in a way that allows them to pace themselves better. (Interested Consuls can find stress management material online and human resources at many companies offer such training.)

Self-Determination

Balanced Self-Determination

The Feeling trait is foundational to the way Consuls decide matters. Their decisions usually support their primary role of nurturer. It fosters their sincere desire to see those who are important to them being safe, happy, and prosperous in the world. They mold their lives around decisions from the heart. As is often the case with those who share the Feeling trait, Consuls value harmony and this also influences their decisions.

Practical Organizing from the Heart

Like a three-legged stool, Consuls' practical combination of Observant and Judging traits, along with the Feeling trait, help Consuls meet their harmonious goals. It's a complete package. Bringing real-time order and stability to the people they care about is the Consul version of nurturing. The welfare of the people in their lives provides their motivation and informs their choices. They will be there when they are needed.

Because of their Observant trait, Consuls connect with the physical world, and this allows them to pick up the cues of those around them readily and to respond accordingly. Their attentive and responsive natures lead people to regard Consuls as nurturing individuals. They fall naturally into the role of parent, giving friend, understanding spouse, nurse, teacher, support staff or even a caring manager at work. They notice when there are signs of distress or discomfort and express their personality by deciding how to ease those problems. Consuls are imaginative problem-solvers when the problems are practical, and their solutions are characteristically useful.

Acceptance of Existing Things

Consuls, when Balanced, are one of the most tolerant types out there. While their first instinct is to fix something that's out of place, or to correct someone's hurtful behavior, they will instead consider the context of the situation. Considering personal relationships, Consuls will always try to give the other person the benefit of doubt. They'll think things like, *Perhaps they're so busy at work that they don't have any time to call* or, *They're going through a hard time right now, and that's why they're acting up*.

Consuls are hyperaware of other's feelings, and they see doing what's traditional as the clearest path to happiness. These traits combined

make for people who make their opinion known (whether or not others asked for it). However, balanced Consuls understand that sometimes the best course of action is to let someone be and allow them to live their life as they chose.

Unbalanced Self-Determination

Meddling

Consuls don't like conflict, but they will engage in it if they must. They try to fix someone's perceived incorrect behavior for that person's own good. This can be something minor like telling a person that being more organized will make them happier, to something major like convincing their friend to break up with a no-good spouse. In both situations, Consuls will state their opinion regardless of whether or not they were asked.

While this can sometimes be irritating to Consuls' friends and family, those who know them know that they are stating this opinion out of a place of love and concern. However, Consuls can make the mistake of believing that their way is the *only* right path available. This rigid point of view can lose Consuls' loved one's very quickly, as love and concern can be easily misconstrued for judgment and harsh criticism.

Hurt Feelings: The Other Side of Sensitivity

The sensitivity that makes Consuls so aware of the needs of others can also work against them if they are feeling the least bit insecure. They might become too sensitive to even the mildest slight. The subtlest dismissive gesture from a loved one may begin to feel like an overwhelming slam: "I work so hard to take care of them, and this is how they treat me?" Taken a step further, when people blatantly criticizes Consuls, it may devastate these sensitive souls.

When they feel hurt, Consuls may resort to tactics like the cold shoulder or severe passive-aggressiveness. Consider a Consul who is angry at their friend. Rather than speaking to their friend, the Consul may pretend that things are well and good, smiling even when they feel awful and hurt. They may say snide things or seek retribution in small, petty ways like not answering their friend's texts. Though they

ultimately hate conflict, they are prone to speak on everything but how awful they may be feeling at that moment, until it ultimately ends up eroding the relationship.

Rebalancing Self-Determination

Some Consuls may become so attached to the idea of harmony that they will do anything to preserve it – leading to conflict avoidance and difficult problems remaining unsolved. So, how do they become unstuck?

The Assertive Consul

Fortunately, there are ways to deal with conflict and problems that avoids any aggressive behaviors. Assertive behavior sits at the midpoint between passive behavior and aggressive behavior. Learning to be more assertive offers a method for standing up for oneself while avoiding hostility, and it's something anyone can learn. (Google: "Assertiveness training.")

One of the assertiveness techniques that might prove helpful for Consuls is a reliance on "I feel..." statements. Coming at others using an accusatory "You..." statement puts them in a defensive position, leading many times to a fight. Consuls may not be comfortable with statements that feel aggressive. If they can instead use a statement which explains how things are affecting them, it will feel less like they are hostile to others. In addition, it's hard for someone to start a fight based on someone else's feelings. People are allowed their feelings, and it's difficult to tell them they shouldn't have them.

For example: Instead of "I work cleaning this house all day and then you come in and you just throw your stuff everywhere. And you just leave it there until I pick it up," they might try: "I feel like you don't care about the time I spent or the work I put into cleaning the house when you don't put your stuff away." The first sets up a fight, but most won't try to argue against a feeling as expressed in the second. The second allows Consuls to talk about how this affects them, and it reflects their emotional state. Not only might such an approach be more palatable to harmony-loving Consuls, it also allows them to bring difficult subjects to the surface more easily. This gives both parties a better chance of resolving any problems.

Self-Adjustment

Balanced Self-Adjustment

The Guardians of Continuity

Consuls are the watchers over a culture's traditions and accepted standards, and it speaks to their love of order and predictability and serves to foster stability. Protocols are reliable, like Consuls themselves. If everything were in a constant state of change, then life would become messy. Imagine arriving at work every day, never knowing if the job requirements and procedures had shifted overnight. Change is important and inevitable, and the mature Consul knows when to adapt. However, within that framework, some constants and points of references must be held in place to prevent chaos. Upholding these standards are an intrinsic part of Consuls' nature.

Consuls' homes are likely to be traditional, with accepted values and norms practiced. At the workplace or at school, they will find themselves aligning with the procedures and expectations of the institution. Consuls will know rules and not only obey them, but if someone ignores the decrees, they will defend and enforce them. As Feeling Extraverts, it may not be in caring Consuls' basic nature to take on a rule-breaker, but order may mean enough to them that they will. Stability is Consuls' superpower, and they will probably protect it.

Without a doubt, like a love song from yesteryear or a meal that conjures pleasant memories, there is a sense of comfort in the familiar. Balanced Consuls exude a perpetual sense of "home." That sense of home might be literal or a metaphor for some form of reliability. Consuls protect "what always has been" and provide society with a sense of healthy continuity. Because of people like Consuls, society is a lot more predictable and steady.

Unbalanced Self-Adjustment

The Challenge of Change

Certainly, Consuls are among those people would call "the salt of the earth." They are practical traditionalists. However, if not balanced, this can carry dangers. Being the salt of the earth doesn't mean they own the planet. Clinging to old ideas – even as things rapidly change – can

produce a protective intolerance if Consuls can't balance established standards with change. It may be difficult for Consuls to view changing morals, evolving methods and disregard for traditional standards and not cast severe judgment in their direction. Some may perpetually pit the old against the new rather than adapt.

Change is difficult for everybody, but Consuls and other Sentinels are the hardest hit when drastic shifts occur. Some Consuls may reject change consistently, and in the 21st Century, they will undoubtedly be socially or professionally handicapped. What was once a Consul fostering traditional standards can become rigidity. What was a mastery of steadiness and stability can devolve into stubbornness.

Intolerance

Hate is not a natural part of Consuls' character by any measure. Any intolerance they experience towards others is likely to be the product of fear more than disdain. If they associate a person or a group of "others" with undermining the traditional standards they fight to uphold, they may regard them as enemies. This can, paradoxically, disturb the harmony they labor so hard to create.

Much of this happens because Consuls have not ventured out outside the boundaries set by the community, and if they have, then they're very reluctant to let go of traditions of old. The fear that comes with change will propel them to try change the different into something more familiar.

Rebalancing Self-Adjustment

Tradition as a Guide

W. Somerset Maugham said, "Tradition is a guide and not a jailer." This might serve as a powerful insight for Consuls. Using it as a guide, Consuls don't diminish tradition, but they also don't enslave themselves to it either. To restore balance against excessive rigidity and intolerance, it may be crucial to put tradition in a more realistic perspective.

Accepting the inevitability of change can be a first step. Learning to blend the old into the new can help Consuls create a more balanced

view. Spotting the difference between maintaining stability and being stubborn can also help Consuls navigate the changing world better. Self-talk and self-examination can be useful here. “Am I really offering helpful insights into how things work, or am I just finding change difficult to handle?” Asking this and similar questions may help.

Reconsidering the Change Agents

Intolerance is an attitude and there is little that combats it apart from changing one’s attitude. It may help Consuls who face this problem to think in terms of efficiency rather than constancy. How many good people or innovative ideas are left behind because of intolerance? Instead of finding individuals threatening, what if instead the word “interesting” was applied. Reframing is deciding to look at something from a different perspective.

Finally, making it a point to look for the good during change or a departure from that which Consuls already know can make change less dire and threatening. Searching for the silver lining and how it applies to their personal goals and interests can make change easier for Consuls. It may even surprise them how much the change works in their favor.

Self-Recognition

Balanced Self-Recognition

Duty Stills Needs a Reward

Consuls will never seek recognition. Doing so makes little sense to them because it's not part of their primary motivation. They see all they do as an expected duty. For them, that would be like others celebrating that they brushed their teeth when they rose in the morning. It's just what one does.

While Consuls may protest when others try to show appreciation for their diligence, it likely pleases them. When others appreciate them, Consuls feel stronger, and feel enthusiastic to continue helping others. They don't need a brass band. A simple "thank you and well-done" is enough for these social and hardworking people.

Finding Ways to Celebrate Victories

While having the praise and approval of others is gratifying, the only guaranteed source is from oneself. Consuls may find they need to be or develop their own cheering section. They might do this in a variety of ways depending on personal preferences. If they prefer introspection they might list their accomplishments or keep a journal, reviewing their challenges and victories daily. Often people set goals and then reward themselves in some small way as a celebration: Consuls might treat themselves to a local concert after they complete a report, for example.

If Consuls need a more social context, as even Introverts sometimes do, they may enlist others with whom they can share a mutual "brag" session. Consuls' willing spouses, family members, or friends may be natural partners to help celebrate victories and accomplishments. One can imagine it turning into a dinner-time ritual with their treasured families, whether natural or extended. "What was your day like?" is likely to assume more weight than just a conversational nicety around a Consul's table. Regardless of how they do it, balanced Consuls will discover some means of assuring they enjoy a sense of belonging. They will uncover methods for reinforcing their sense of value.

Unbalanced Self-Recognition

While the amount of recognition one gets might sound like a vanity concern, it can go deeper. Without some expression of appreciation, people can forget they belong or have a purpose. Motivation ideally comes from within, but humans are social animals, and they are the rare individuals who don't desire some recognition for their contributions. Unsung heroes may appear noble as they secretly crave someone noticing.

Consuls who don't receive recognition for their work may imagine others not caring about what they do, that someone is taking advantage of them or that they aren't a vital part of a group. And since Consuls don't typically like to confront others, they may allow these thoughts to fester. None of these negative ideas foster a sense of belonging. They are likely to drain energy and enthusiasm.

Consuls may also try to cope ineffectively using one or both of two methods:

Artificially Proving Importance

The first is proving one's importance. This can take a wrong turn if it feels forced and care is not taken to soften it. Think of the stereotypical TV sitcom version of the bureaucrat behind the counter at the DMV who won't cut the customer a break under any circumstances, nor will they even take the time to hear them out. The hidden message is, "See I'm important enough to belong here." On TV, they exaggerate situations for laughs. Milder, more realistic versions might seep into the everyday life of some Consuls if they aren't getting the recognition they deserve.

The Passive-Aggressive Approach

The second is passive-aggressive behavior. That's striking out at others by not doing something as an alternative to a direct assault. The person who typically makes a beautiful breakfast everyday suddenly presents undercooked eggs with blackened toast. The hidden message, "Now you'll pay attention when I do it well." (And the cook may not even do it consciously.)

People will usually find a way to feel valued – even if they have to do so in maladaptive ways. If it feels like Consuls are forcing others to acknowledge their value, it will come across as demanding and abrasive. Finding a more organic means of accomplishing the same thing can create pleasant experiences and help cement respectful relationships and some methods will be explored below.

Rebalancing Self-Recognition

Self-Promotion and the Basic Need for Recognition

A sense of belonging is a basic human need, and Consuls dislike self-promotion for the sheer sake of self-promotion. Aided by their Extraverted qualities, they can feel easily lonely if there aren't people around them. Some people are naturals at self-promotion and some people are not.

For some people, self-promotion might be thought of as a stress-management technique because it helps individuals relax more into their lives and feel more comfortable in their skins. Rather than experiencing stress at feeling left behind because flashier types seem to be hogging all the glory, Consuls and other grounded people may want to explore strategies for getting the attention they deserve. This can help them get ahead and feel like a vital part of any group to which they belong.

Self-Promotion as a Relation with One's Self and with Others

At first, Consuls may want to promote themselves to... themselves. Taking inventory of one's own value can be the first step to gaining the confidence needed to shine publicly. Even if self-promotion goes no further, Consuls can assure themselves of their belonging in a group.

Consuls can be insular, and that alone can cause them to fade into the wallpaper. But they still value relationships. If they can think of self-promotion as part of a relationship, they might find it easier to tell others who they are and what they do. This perspective may feel less like they are "blowing their own horn" and more like they are sharing themselves openly with others.

The Elevator Pitch

And, lastly, there's the old reliable elevator speech: the 30 second speech that could be given during the span of typical elevator ride that sums up who the one giving the pitch is. It is a way to brand oneself and to get others to pay healthy attention. It doesn't have to be confined to professional use.

As an example, Bobby's Consul dad might present himself to Bobby's fifth grade teacher and other parents at the PTA meeting in the following fashion: "I'm Bobby's dad, chauffeur, knee-scrape doctor, and home study hall supervisor. While he depends on his mom to help him with everyday homework, I'm around for his larger projects. So, if the diorama doesn't cut it, you can blame Bobby, but my hand was involved in the crime as well." (Obviously, running around a room repeating this can sound odd, so variations on a theme are acceptable and perhaps preferred.)

This is a breezy yet defining description of what Bobby's dad does for him. It's even slightly self-effacing for those who are more comfortable being humble. Bobby's dad may have a work version of this or even a golf course version. It's like a commercial slogan that repeats the speakers' attributes and gives others a chance to know them and their role in the group. It can be very effective at bringing someone who is usually in the background more to the forefront.

Final Words

Loving through Self-Love

Like a seedling poking its head through the soil in the early spring, growth rarely happens without something emerging from the comforts of the familiar. As much as Consuls love the familiar, they love esteem more. Consuls who embrace balance and self-care will discover that they more easily earn that esteem. This alone should prove motivating for Consuls seeking to be their best selves. People with this personality type are not slouches. They are perfectly capable of taking the risks necessary to learn and grow, not just for others but for themselves.

More importantly, Consuls are protectors and nurturers. Consuls who develop a satisfying quality of life likely share that satisfaction with the people they love. Happy Consuls carry with them a bubble of happiness that influences and engulfs others. There are so many ways in which nurturing oneself contributes to nurturing others. Finding the proper mix of self-care and caring for others is likely the key to Consuls' growth.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you direct your personal growth journey? Explore our Personal Growth Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Consul Guide to Careers*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Consul Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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